

SMART INDIA HACKATHON 2026

Setu — startup-friendly public procurement

A working prototype of a procurement route that startups can win

PROBLEM STATEMENT ID

[Enter PS ID]

PS CATEGORY

Software

PROBLEM STATEMENT TITLE

[Enter PS title]

TEAM ID

[Enter Team ID]

THEME

[Enter theme]

TEAM NAME

[Enter registered team name]

Setu: a procurement route startups can win

PROPOSED SOLUTION

- Department posts a **problem**, not a rigid tender specification
- Startups apply with an approach — no turnover or past-contract filter
- An **independent evaluator** scores the applications and selects
- Winner runs a **paid pilot**; a successful pilot converts into a contract

HOW IT ADDRESSES THE PROBLEM

- Removes the eligibility rules that lock young companies out
- Makes selection auditable: every decision is written down
- Gives the startup revenue and a government reference customer
- Gives the department a tested solution before it commits

WHAT MAKES IT DIFFERENT

- The department that writes the problem does not choose the winner — an independent evaluator does
- Every rejection carries a written reason the applicant can read

The prototype is live and demoable today

Problem posted

Startups
apply

Evaluator
picks

Paid pilot

Contract

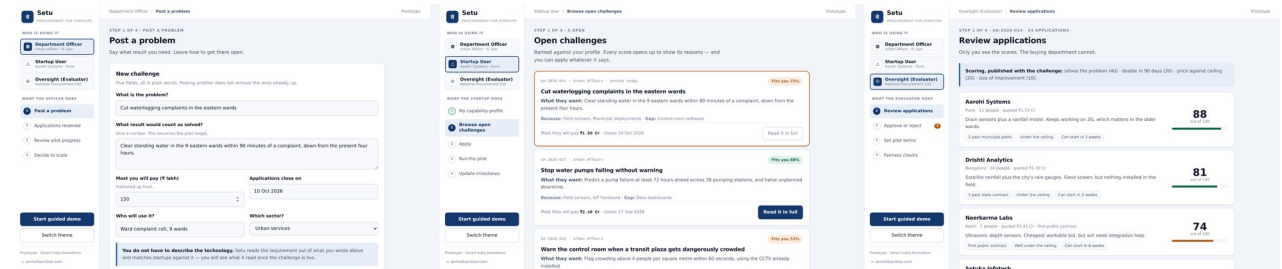
TECHNOLOGIES USED

- Vanilla JavaScript, no framework
- Hand-written CSS design system
- Strict Content Security Policy
- Deployed on Cloudflare Pages

METHODOLOGY

- All five stages modelled end to end
- Guided demo walks a judge through the route
- Separate views for department, startup, evaluator

DEMO VIDEO



The hard part is trust in the process, not the technology

WHY IT IS FEASIBLE

- It is a route inside existing procurement practice, not a change in law
- The full flow already runs as a working prototype
- Static front end, no server to procure — hosting cost is negligible
- The three roles map to people a department already has
- A department can start with one problem and one pilot

RISKS AND MITIGATION

Challenge	How we handle it
Evaluator capacity	A small panel per problem, scoring against published criteria
Departments distrust an outside decision	The department sets the acceptance test; the evaluator only scores against it
Pilots that never convert	Fixed pilot scope and a written conversion condition, agreed up front
Unfair or opaque rejections	Every rejection is written down and readable by the applicant

A paid pilot turns a first-time supplier into a proven one



For startups

- A first government customer, with no turnover history needed
- A paid pilot, not an unpaid proof of concept
- Written feedback even when they lose



For departments

- The problem is set as an outcome, not a specification
- The solution is tested before any long commitment
- A written record for every decision



For public spending

- Money follows evidence from the pilot
- A failed pilot costs a pilot, not a contract
- Decisions stand up in audit

WIDER BENEFITS

- **Social:** public projects open to first-time suppliers, including teams outside the big metros
- **Economic:** pilot-first buying limits the cost of a purchase that does not work
- **Both:** domestic startups earn revenue and a public reference they can sell on

Research and references

WORKING PROTOTYPE

- Live prototype:
anmolkanitkar.com/projects/setu
- Source:
github.com/anmolkanitkar/anmolkanitkar.com — public/projects/setu
- Built and hosted by the team; open to inspection by the judges

PROBLEM STATEMENT

- Smart India Hackathon 2026, Problem Statement [ID] — startup-friendly public procurement
- Theme: [as listed on the SIH portal]
- SIH Idea Submission template, 2026 edition

POLICY AND RESEARCH SOURCES

- [Source 1: public procurement policy for startups — publisher, year, link]
- [Source 2: GeM or Startup India procurement relaxations — publisher, year, link]
- [Source 3: a departmental pilot or challenge programme used as precedent — publisher, year, link]